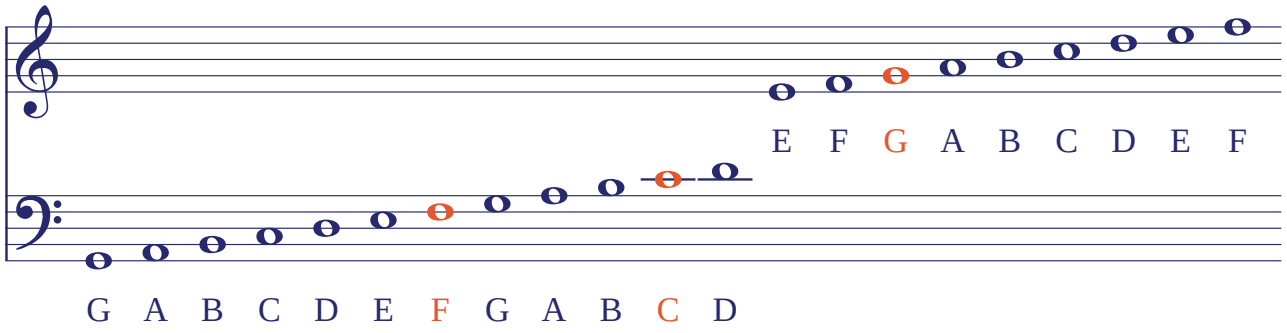
PART I · PITCH · 4

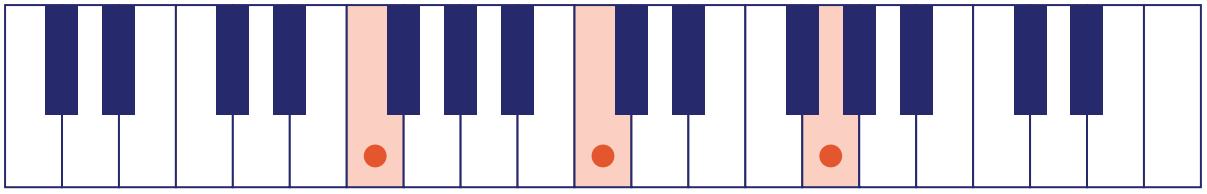
Reading the notes

Every line and space has one letter. You do not have to learn them all at once: start from a note you always know, then **step** or **skip** to the one you want.

THE SECRET

Start from a note you know (bass F, Middle C, treble G), then step or skip.

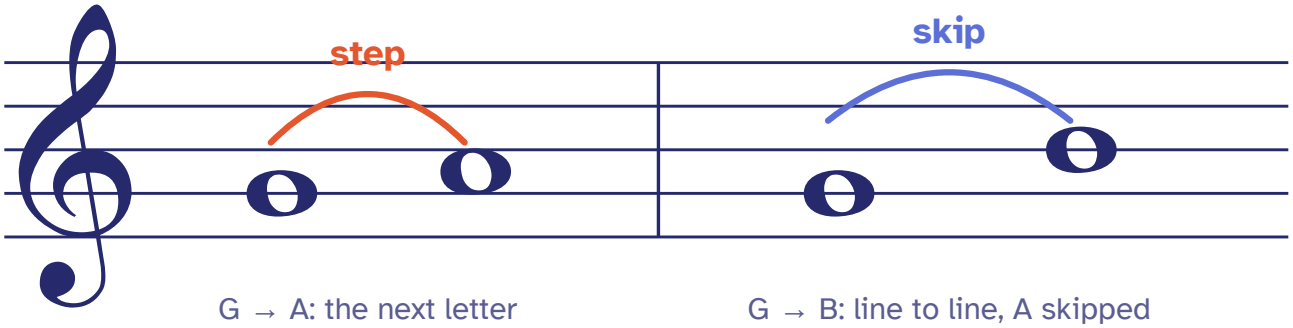




Middle C in the middle; treble G and bass F, the clef notes, either side. Every line and space is the next letter, with its own key underneath (the keyboard starts on G, so its first black keys belong to a group of three).

THE RULE

Step: to the very next line or space (one letter on). Skip: line to the next line, or space to the next space (two letters on).



G → A: the next letter

G → B: line to line, A skipped

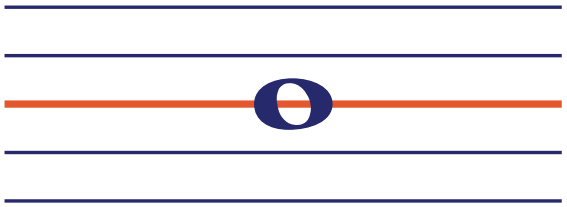
PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Read the shape, not just the notes

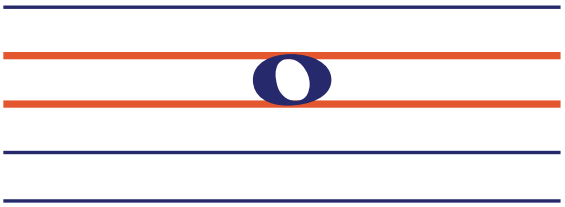
Good readers see the jumps before the letters. Notes that touch, line then space, are a **step**: the next letter. Notes with one line between them, line to line or space to space, are a **skip**: one letter missed out. Name the first note, then let the shape name the rest: up a step, up a skip, down a step.

Line note or space note?



line note

a line runs through its middle

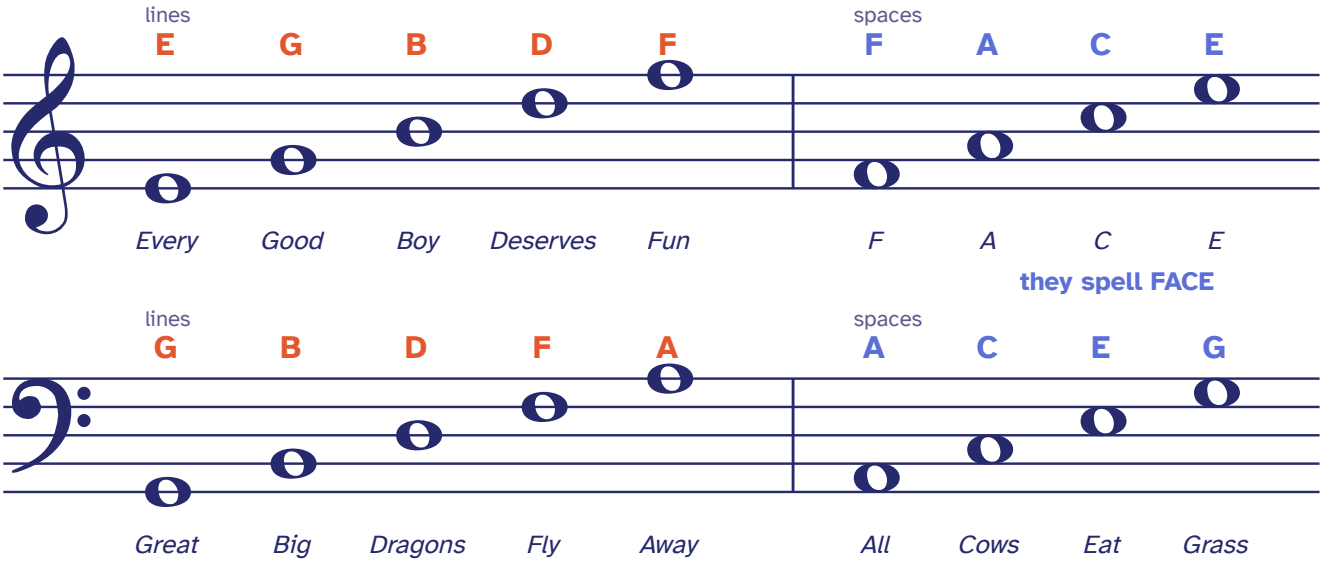


space note

sits between two lines, touching both

Count both from the bottom: line 1 is the bottom line, space 1 the bottom space.

Words to remember the lines and spaces



PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Read a line note with its sentence



1. **Treble lines:** *Every Good Boy Deserves Fun*. The red note on line 4 is the fourth word.
2. **Bass lines:** *Great Big Dragons Fly Away*. The red note on line 3 is the third word.
3. **Check each** from its clef note: treble G, bass F.

Treble line 4: **D** (Deserves). Bass line 3: **D** (Dragons). Same letter, different keys: the clef decides.

EXAMPLE 2

One line, two notes

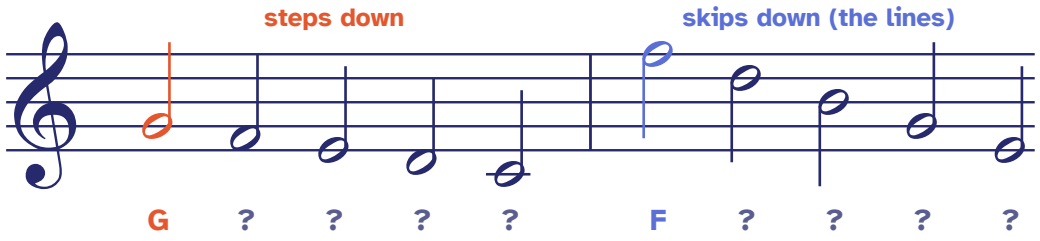


1. **Look at the red notes:** both sit on the bottom line.
2. **Now look at the clefs:** treble on the left, bass on the right.
3. **Use each clef's sentence:** the first word of the treble lines, *Every...*; the first word of the bass lines, *Great...*.

Treble bottom line: **E** (*Every*). Bass bottom line: **G** (*Great*). Same line, different note: always read the **clef** first.

EXAMPLE 3

Read it downwards



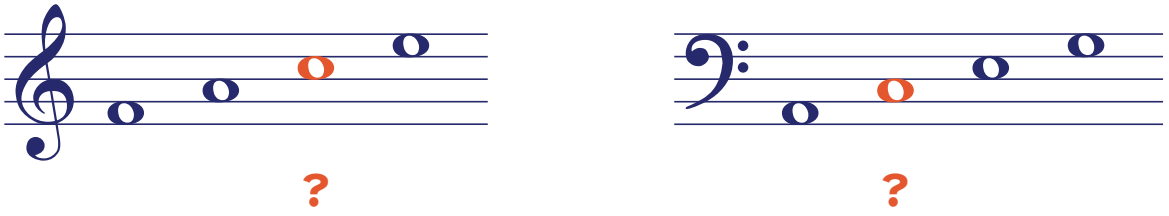
1. **Start on G**, the clef note: line 2.
2. **Each step down** is the letter before: say the alphabet backwards.
3. **Skips down** go back two letters. Start on F, the top line.

Steps: G **F E D C**, down to Middle C. Skips: F **D B G E**, the lines backwards.

PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find Treble C and Bass C
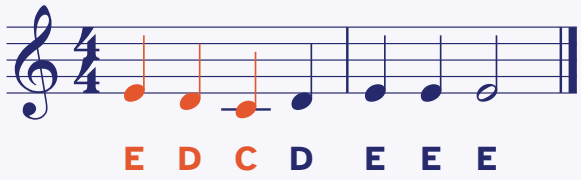


1. **Treble spaces** spell *FACE*: space 3 is the third letter.
2. **Bass spaces:** *All Cows Eat Grass*: space 2 is the second word.
3. **Play both:** one octave either side of Middle C.

Treble space 3: **C**, Treble C. Bass space 2: **C**, Bass C. Mirror images, an octave above and below Middle C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Mary Had a Little Lamb



E D C: **line, space, Middle C's own little line**, one step down each time. Read the shape and the tune walks down with it.

Try it. Read the notes aloud before you play them.

THINK OF IT The clef notes are lamp posts on a dark road: walk from the nearest one and you are never lost.

TRAP

- × Naming bass notes with treble names: in the bass, the bottom line is G, not E.
- × Mixing up step and skip: a step changes line to space; a skip stays on lines (or on spaces).
- × Mistaking a space note for a line note: a line runs through a line note; a space note sits between two lines.
- × Counting lines from the top: line 1 is always the bottom line.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the keyboard p. 29 · Ledger lines p. 36

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 7–8 · Online: Line and Space Names · Steps & Skips